

Korean BBQ

— The Complete Operator Blueprint

Recipes · Food Costs · Service Scripts · Staff Workflow · Weekly Prep · P&L Model
US Market Edition · 2025

20–26%	20	\$55–80	\$29.99
TARGET FOOD COST	MENU ITEMS	AVG SPEND / HEAD	GUIDE PRICE

// CHEF'S LENS — KOREA

"Korean BBQ is not a meal — it is an event. The table grill is a stage, the banchan are the opening act, and the meat is the performance. The operator who understands this builds a restaurant where guests don't just eat — they participate. Nunchi — the Korean art of reading the room — is the invisible service standard that separates good Korean BBQ from great Korean BBQ. This guide gives you the technique, the costs, the workflows, and the scripts. The nunchi is yours to develop, one service at a time."

1 ENTRÉES — BANCHAN & STARTERS

Banchan philosophy: Banchan (side dishes) are served complimentary with every Korean BBQ meal. They are not free — they are your most powerful hospitality tool. A table arriving to 6–8 banchan already feels welcomed, fed, and engaged before the meat arrives. The cost per table (~\$2.80) is the best marketing spend in your restaurant. Never reduce banchan quality to save money.

Banchan Set — Six House Side Dishes

Kimchi · Japchae · Spinach Namul · Bean Sprout Namul · Pickled Radish · Seasoned Tofu · Complimentary per table

5 min service Complimentary Cost \$2.80/table

BANCHAN COMPONENTS (PER TABLE OF 4)

BANCHAN	PORTION	COST
Baechu kimchi (fermented napa cabbage)	80g	\$0.45
Japchae (glass noodles, sesame, veg)	60g	\$0.42
Sigeumchi namul (sesame spinach)	50g	\$0.28
Kongnamul (seasoned bean sprouts)	50g	\$0.18
Danmuji (pickled yellow radish)	40g	\$0.22
Dubu jorim (spicy braised tofu)	60g	\$0.35
Ganjang (soy dipping sauce)	20ml	\$0.06
Ssamjang (bbq dipping paste)	30g	\$0.28
Total cost per table		\$2.24
Cost per table		\$2.24
Tables per service (40-seat)		10 tables
Daily banchan cost		\$22.40
Revenue it protects		\$2,200+ daily
ROI on banchan		98x

- 1

Kimchi — your identity in a bowl: Make your kimchi in-house. A 5kg batch fermented for minimum 3 days at room temperature then refrigerated produces the authentic sour-spicy-funky flavour that store-bought kimchi never replicates. Napa cabbage, gochugaru (Korean red pepper flakes), fish sauce, garlic, ginger, spring onion, daikon. The fermentation is alive — taste it daily and serve at the right stage. Fresh kimchi (geotjeori) is bright and crunchy; aged kimchi (mukimchi) is deeper and more sour. Both have their place on the table.
- 2

Japchae — your most labour-intensive banchan but worth it: Glass noodles (dangmyeon) stir-fried with spinach, carrot, mushroom, onion, soy, sesame oil, and sugar. The key: cook each vegetable separately, then combine. This preserves individual textures and colours — a mixed stir-fry produces mushy, grey japchae. Batch weekly — japchae holds well refrigerated for 4 days. Serve at room temperature or slightly warm.

3 **Namul — the art of seasoning simply:** Namul are blanched vegetables seasoned with sesame oil, garlic, soy, and toasted sesame seeds. Spinach namul and bean sprout namul together take 20 minutes to prepare in large batches. The seasoning must be assertive — namul served on a Korean BBQ table competes with bold grilled meat flavours. Under-seasoned namul disappears. Taste aggressively and season accordingly.

4 **Replenish without being asked:** The most important banchan service rule: refill any empty bowl before the guest notices it is empty. This is nunchi in practice. Station your servers to scan banchan levels at every table pass. "Would you like more kimchi?" is acceptable. Silently replacing an empty bowl before being asked is exceptional. Train for the second standard.

***Chef's Tip:** Your banchan set communicates your entire kitchen philosophy to the guest within 60 seconds of sitting down. Eight small bowls of carefully made, beautifully presented Korean side dishes says: this kitchen cares. Eight bowls of tired, store-bought banchan says the opposite. The \$2.24 cost is the most important investment per table you make.*

GLUTEN (soy sauce) SOYA SESAME FISH (fish sauce in kimchi)

Vegan option: omit fish sauce, use ganjang only

Haemul Pajeon — Seafood Spring Onion Pancake

Crispy seafood pancake, spring onion, squid, prawn, ganjang dipping sauce · Sell: \$14.99

12 min

Entrée

FC 16%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 1 LARGE PANCAKE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pajeon batter (flour, rice flour, egg, ice water)	150g batter	\$0.28
Spring onions (whole, laid across pancake)	6 stalks / 80g	\$0.22
Squid (cleaned, sliced into rings)	50g	\$0.55
Prawn (small, peeled)	40g	\$0.62
Ganjang dipping sauce (soy, rice vinegar, sesame, chilli)	40ml	\$0.12
Sesame oil, toasted sesame (finish)	5ml	\$0.06
Total cost per serve		\$1.85
Cost per serve		\$1.85
Sell price		\$14.99
Food cost %		12.3%
Contribution margin		\$13.14

- 1

Rice flour is the secret to crispiness: A 50/50 blend of plain flour and rice flour creates a lighter, crispier pancake than all-purpose flour alone. Use ice-cold water — cold batter hits the hot pan and creates immediate, aggressive crisping. Mix batter minimally — lumps are acceptable. Over-mixed batter develops gluten and produces a chewy, doughy pancake instead of the shatteringly crispy exterior that defines great pajeon.
- 2

Lay spring onions lengthwise, not chopped: The visual signature of pajeon is whole spring onions running the full length of the pancake, visible through the batter. Lay them across the oiled pan first, pour batter over, then press the seafood into the top. The green of the spring onion showing through the cooked pancake is the presentation. Never chop the spring onions — it destroys the visual and structural integrity of the dish.
- 3

High heat, no touching for 4 minutes: The bottom crust forms only if left completely undisturbed. High heat, well-oiled cast iron or flat griddle, 4 minutes without touching. The edges will begin to crisp and release from the pan. Press gently with a spatula — if it moves freely, it's ready to flip. Flip once with confidence using two spatulas simultaneously. The bottom should be deep golden and completely rigid. Cook the second side 3 minutes.
- 4

Cut and serve immediately: Cut into 6–8 wedges with a sharp knife or pizza cutter. Serve immediately — pajeon softens within 5 minutes as steam from the seafood migrates into the crust. The ganjang dipping sauce (soy, rice vinegar, a few drops sesame oil, sliced red chilli) provides the acidity that cuts through the oil. Brief the table: "Eat it hot — pajeon is best in the first 3 minutes."

***Chef's Tip:** Pajeon is your highest-margin entrée and the dish most likely to generate a reorder. At \$14.99 with 12.3% food cost, it contributes \$13.14 per serve. The theatrical sizzle and visual impact when it arrives at a BBQ table makes it a guaranteed social media post. Train staff to serve it with the dipping sauce already poured into the small dish — not to the side still in a bottle.*

GLUTEN (flour)

EGGS

CRUSTACEANS (prawn)

MOLLUSCS (squid)

SOYA

SESAME

Tteokbokki — Spicy Rice Cakes

Chewy rice cakes, gochujang sauce, fish cake, spring onion, sesame · Sell: \$11.99

10 min Entrée FC 14%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Garae-tteok (cylindrical rice cakes, fresh or frozen)	180g	\$0.72
Gochujang (Korean fermented red pepper paste)	40g	\$0.28
Gochugaru (red pepper flakes, heat adjust)	5g	\$0.06
Eomuk (Korean fish cake sheets, sliced)	60g	\$0.38
Anchovy-kelp dashi (sauce base)	200ml	\$0.22
Sugar, soy sauce (balance)	15g	\$0.05
Spring onion, sesame seeds, boiled egg (garnish)	20g	\$0.15

Total cost per serve	\$1.86
Cost per serve	\$1.86
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	15.5%
Contribution margin	\$10.13

- 1

Anchovy-kelp dashi is non-negotiable: The sauce base for tteokbokki must be built on myeolchi-dasima yuksu — anchovy and kelp stock. Simmer 10 large dried anchovies (heads and innards removed) and a 10cm piece of dried kelp in 500ml water for 15 minutes. This stock provides the deep savoury foundation that makes tteokbokki taste genuinely Korean rather than just spicy. Plain water produces a flat, one-dimensional sauce.
- 2

Gochujang ratio determines everything: Gochujang is fermented — it has sweetness, umami, and heat simultaneously. The standard ratio is 3 tbsp gochujang to 1 tbsp gochugaru per 200ml dashi. Adjust gochugaru up for more heat, down for milder. For US market: offer mild, medium, and spicy options at ordering — "our regular is medium, our spicy is genuinely hot." This conversation manages expectations and prevents complaints.
- 3

Rice cake texture is everything: Fresh rice cakes should be soft with a distinct chew. Frozen rice cakes must be soaked in cold water 30 minutes before cooking to rehydrate — straight from frozen they remain hard in the centre. Simmer in the sauce 8-10 minutes — the rice cakes absorb the sauce and plump up. They should be completely cooked through (no white centre) with a glossy, sauce-coated exterior. Over-cooked rice cakes become mushy and lose their signature chew.
- 4

Serve bubbling hot in a stone pot if possible: Tteokbokki served in a dolsot (stone pot) continues cooking at the table and stays hot throughout the meal. If stone pots are unavailable, a small cast iron skillet works. The visual of a bubbling red sauce arriving at the table generates excitement and table envy. Other tables will order it based on the visual alone — this is free marketing within your dining room.

Chef's Tip: Tteokbokki is Korea's most beloved street food and is having a massive moment in the US market driven by K-drama and K-pop cultural exposure. The average American guest aged 25-35 has seen it on Netflix and wants to try it. Your job is to make it as good as the version they imagined. The anchovy dashi, proper gochujang ratio, and correct rice cake texture together produce that result.

GLUTEN (gochujang, fish cake) FISH (anchovy dashi, fish cake) SOYA
EGGS (boiled egg garnish)

Japchae — Glass Noodle Stir-Fry

Dangmyeon glass noodles, mushroom, spinach, carrot, sesame soy glaze · Sell: \$13.99

10 min Entrée FC 15%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — ENTRÉE PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Dangmyeon (sweet potato glass noodles)	100g dry / 250g cooked	\$0.42
Shiitake mushrooms (sliced, sautéed)	60g	\$0.45
Baby spinach (blanched, squeezed)	50g	\$0.22
Carrot (julienne, sautéed)	40g	\$0.08
Onion (sliced thin, caramelised)	40g	\$0.06
Soy sauce, sesame oil, sugar, garlic (seasoning)	30ml	\$0.22
Toasted sesame seeds, spring onion (garnish)	5g	\$0.06

Total cost per serve \$1.51

Cost per serve	\$1.51
Sell price	\$13.99
Food cost %	10.8%
Contribution margin	\$12.48

- 1

Cook each component separately — always: The cardinal rule of japchae is mise en place. Each vegetable must be cooked separately, seasoned separately, and combined only at the final moment. Spinach: blanch 30 seconds, squeeze bone dry, season with sesame oil and salt. Carrots: stir-fry 2 minutes in sesame oil, season. Mushrooms: sauté until golden, add garlic and soy. Each component has a distinct flavour and texture — combined cooking produces a homogeneous, flavourless stir-fry.
- 2

Dangmyeon cooking technique: Boil noodles 6–8 minutes until fully transparent and tender but still with a slight chew. Rinse in cold water immediately. Drain completely — wet noodles dilute the seasoning and make the japchae watery. Toss warm noodles with soy sauce, sesame oil, sugar, and minced garlic immediately while warm — the warm noodles absorb the seasoning more effectively than cold noodles.
- 3

Final assembly — fold, don't stir: Combine all components gently using tongs or your hands (clean, gloved). Folding preserves the individual components; vigorous stirring breaks the noodles and mashes the vegetables. Taste and adjust — japchae should be balanced between soy saltiness, sesame nuttiness, and a gentle sweetness from the sugar. The final dish should be glossy from the sesame oil — this visual signals proper seasoning.
- 4

Serve warm or room temperature: Japchae is equally good warm, room temperature, or slightly chilled — it is one of the few Korean dishes that travels well across temperatures. As an entrée, serve slightly warm. Garnish generously with toasted sesame seeds and sliced spring onion. Optional: add thin strips of bulgogi beef for a premium version at +\$4 upcharge. This variation increases the entrée sell price to \$17.99 at minimal added cost.

Chef's Tip: Japchae is your best vegetarian entrée and at 10.8% food cost your second-best margin starter. Batch produce the noodle base and individual components daily — assemble to order in under 3 minutes. This speed allows you to offer it as a banchan top-up ("Would you like a full japchae as a starter?") which converts a complimentary side into a \$13.99 revenue item.

GLUTEN (soy sauce) SOYA SESAME GLUTEN-FREE option: use tamari VEGAN ✓

Sundubu Jjigae — Soft Tofu Stew

Extra-soft tofu, clams, prawn, gochugaru broth, egg, steamed rice · Sell: \$15.99

12 min

Entrée / Light Main

FC 18%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Sundubu (extra-soft silken tofu, tube pack)	200g	\$0.65
Clams (littleneck, scrubbed)	80g	\$0.88
Prawn (medium, peeled)	40g	\$0.62
Anchovy-kelp dashi (base)	250ml	\$0.28
Gochugaru, gochujang, garlic, sesame oil (seasoning)	20g	\$0.18
Raw egg (cracked in at end)	1 egg	\$0.35
Spring onion, steamed rice (side)	180g rice	\$0.28

Total cost per serve\$3.24

Cost per serve	\$3.24
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	20.3%
Contribution margin	\$12.75

- 1

The dolsot (stone pot) is essential: Sundubu jjigae must be served in a dolsot — the traditional Korean earthenware pot that retains extreme heat. The pot is heated on the stove empty until smoking, then oil and gochugaru are added (they sizzle and bloom instantly), followed by garlic, seafood, dashi, and finally the tofu. The pot arrives at the table still at a violent boil. This theatrical presentation is as important as the flavour — the sound of bubbling soup arriving at the table is one of the great sensory moments in Korean dining.
- 2

Gochugaru blooming technique: Add gochugaru and sesame oil to the hot empty dolsot first — the direct heat blooms the chilli's colour and aroma compounds in seconds. This technique is why Korean sundubu has a brilliant red colour and deep chilli flavour that simply adding gochugaru to water never achieves. The oil carries the fat-soluble colour compounds (capsanthin) and distributes them through the entire soup.
- 3

Tofu handling — never stir: Sundubu is added in large spoonfuls directly from the tube — never sliced or diced. The irregular torn pieces create more surface area for the broth to penetrate. Once in the pot, do not stir — the soft tofu breaks apart if agitated and you lose the dramatic large-piece presentation. The tofu cooks in the bubbling broth in 2-3 minutes. It should be just set — warm throughout but still trembling.
- 4

Crack the egg tableside: Bring the bubbling sundubu to the table and crack one raw egg into the centre in front of the guest. The residual heat of the pot cooks the egg to a soft, jammy consistency within 2 minutes. This tableside moment is the dish's signature — it is engaging, dramatic, and ensures the egg is perfectly cooked. Brief the guest: "The egg will be ready in about 2 minutes — stir it into the soup when you're ready."

***Chef's Tip:** Sundubu jjigae is your most warming, comforting dish — the one guests order when they want to feel taken care of. It is also your best cold-weather revenue driver. At \$15.99 with a \$12.75 margin, it's excellent value. The tableside egg crack is your most theatrical service moment after the BBQ grill itself — train every server to do it confidently and without rushing.*

SOYA (tofu)

FISH (anchovy dashi)

CRUSTACEANS (prawn)

MOLLUSCS (clams)

EGGS

Dakgangjeong — Crispy Glazed Chicken Bites

Double-fried chicken, sweet soy gochujang glaze, peanuts, sesame · Sell: \$13.99

12 min

Entrée

FC 15%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, bite-sized cubes)	160g	\$1.13
Potato starch coating	30g	\$0.04
Dakgangjeong glaze (soy, gochujang, honey, garlic, ginger, rice vinegar)	50ml	\$0.38
Crushed peanuts	15g	\$0.12
Toasted sesame, sliced red chilli, spring onion	5g	\$0.06
Frying oil	—	\$0.10
Total cost per serve		\$1.83
Cost per serve		\$1.83
Sell price		\$13.99
Food cost %		13.1%
Contribution margin		\$12.16

- 1 Double fry for maximum crunch:** First fry at **160°C / 320°F** for 4 minutes — cooks through without browning. Rest 3 minutes on a rack. Second fry at **190°C / 374°F** for 90 seconds — caramelises the starch coating to a shattering crunch. The resting period is critical — moisture migrates to the surface, then converts to steam in the second fry, expanding the crust from the inside.
- 2 Glaze application — toss immediately from the fryer:** The glaze (gochujang, honey, soy, garlic, ginger, rice vinegar, reduced to syrup) should be warm and pourable. Toss the just-fried chicken in the glaze immediately — the residual heat of the chicken caramelises the sugars on contact, creating a sticky, lacquered coating. Allow to glaze for 30 seconds, tossing constantly, then plate immediately before the crust softens.
- 3 Peanuts must be added last:** Crushed peanuts go on after glazing, never in the glaze itself. In the glaze, peanuts absorb moisture and lose their crunch. Added at plating, they provide a textural contrast that makes every bite more complex. This detail separates technically executed dakgangjeong from mediocre Korean fried chicken.

Chef's Tip: Dakgangjeong is your most reorderable entrée — the sweet-spicy-sticky-crunchy combination is genuinely addictive. Tables that order it as a starter almost always order a second round. Price the second round at full price — there is no discount for reorders. This is intentional: the first order is driven by curiosity, the second by genuine craving.

GLUTEN (soy, gochujang)

SOYA

PEANUTS

SESAME

2 MAIN DISHES — BBQ & KITCHEN

Menu engineering note: Korean BBQ mains split into two categories — table-grilled proteins (high engagement, high spend) and kitchen-prepared dishes (faster service, lower labour). A well-engineered Korean BBQ menu balances both. The grill items drive the experience and revenue; the kitchen items serve the guests who don't grill, increase table variety, and reduce grill bottlenecks during peak service.

Chadolbaegi — Thinly Sliced Beef Brisket (Table Grill)

Paper-thin beef brisket, table-grilled, ssam wraps, ssamjang, garlic, green chilli · Sell: \$28.99 / 200g

- 3 min grill
- BBQ Main
- FC 26%
- Signature

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 200G PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef brisket (paper-thin sliced, 1-2mm, frozen block)	200g	\$4.20
Perilla leaves (kkaennip) + butter lettuce (ssam wraps)	8 leaves each	\$0.65
Ssamjang (fermented soybean dipping paste)	30g	\$0.28
Garlic cloves (whole, for grilling)	6 cloves	\$0.08
Green chilli slices, sliced spring onion	10g	\$0.06
Sesame oil + salt dipping dish	10ml	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$5.35
Cost per serve		\$5.35
Sell price		\$28.99
Food cost %		18.5%
Contribution margin		\$23.64

- 1

Slicing technique is the product: Chadolbaegi brisket must be sliced paper-thin — 1-2mm maximum. Partially freeze the brisket block (2 hours in the freezer) and slice on a meat slicer or very sharp knife. The thin slices cook in 60-90 seconds on a hot grill — they curl and caramelise almost instantly. Thick-cut brisket requires longer cooking, dries out, and misses the entire point of the dish. The partial-freeze slicing technique is a non-negotiable kitchen standard.
- 2

The ssam wrap ritual — teach it at the table: The eating ritual for chadolbaegi: take a perilla leaf or lettuce leaf, place a piece of just-grilled brisket, add a small amount of ssamjang, a grilled garlic clove, a piece of green chilli if desired, fold and eat in one bite. This is ssam — the Korean wrap technique. Brief every first-time table: "The traditional way to eat this is as a wrap — I'll show you." This education moment is a hospitality touchstone that guests remember and recount.
- 3

Grill management — change the grill grate frequently: Brisket fat renders heavily and accumulates on the grill grate. Burnt fat produces acrid, bitter smoke that flavours subsequent meat negatively. Change the grill grate every 2-3 orders or when visible carbon build-up occurs. This requires a clean grate system — pre-heat replacement grates before service, swap mid-meal without disruption. Clean grill = clean flavour = repeat customers.
- 4

Sesame oil and salt — the purist's dip: A small dish of premium sesame oil with a pinch of flaky sea salt alongside the ssamjang is the Korean BBQ purist's preference. The just-cooked brisket dipped briefly in sesame oil and salt highlights the clean beef flavour without masking it. Offer both: "We have ssamjang — the fermented paste — and sesame oil and salt. Try both and see which you prefer." The choice positions your staff as knowledgeable and creates a personal dining moment.

Chef's Tip: Chadolbaegi at \$28.99 with \$23.64 contribution margin is your single highest-revenue item. A table of 4 ordering two rounds generates \$115.96 in revenue from this dish alone before drinks. The interaction of grilling, wrapping, and sharing creates memories — the guest doesn't just remember eating good beef; they remember the whole experience. This is why Korean BBQ retains customers better than almost any other format.

- SOYA (ssamjang)
- GLUTEN (ssamjang)
- SESAME

Samgyeopsal — Thick-Cut Pork Belly (Table Grill)

200g thick pork belly, table-grilled, ssam wraps, kimchi, ssamjang, garlic · Sell: \$24.99

- 8 min grill
- BBQ Main
- FC 22%
- Best Seller

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 200G PORTION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pork belly (skin-on, 1.5–2cm thick slices)	200g	\$2.70
Perilla + butter lettuce (ssam wraps)	8 leaves each	\$0.65
Ssamjang	30g	\$0.28
Kimchi (aged, for grilling alongside)	60g	\$0.22
Whole garlic cloves (grilled)	6 cloves	\$0.08
Sesame oil + salt dipping dish	10ml	\$0.08
Total cost per serve		\$4.01
Cost per serve		\$4.01
Sell price		\$24.99
Food cost %		16.0%
Contribution margin		\$20.98

- 1

Samgyeopsal is your volume driver: Pork belly is the most ordered item in Korean BBQ restaurants globally — in Korea, samgyeopsal is a cultural institution, eaten at least weekly by millions. The US market is learning this. Your samgyeopsal must be sourced well (skin-on, consistent fat-to-meat ratio, 1.5–2cm thick), stored correctly (well-wrapped, used within 3 days of delivery), and sliced to the precise thickness that allows 7–8 minutes of table grilling without drying out.
- 2

Grilling kimchi alongside — the key technique: Place aged kimchi directly on the grill alongside the pork belly in the final 3 minutes of cooking. The kimchi caramelises, loses its raw fermented edge, and develops a sweet, intensely savoury flavour that is one of the great taste combinations in Korean cuisine — grilled pork fat + caramelised kimchi. Brief the guest to try this combination: "Try a bite of the grilled kimchi with the pork — it's a classic Korean flavour pairing."
- 3

The scissors technique: Korean BBQ restaurants use kitchen scissors to cut grilled pork belly into bite-sized pieces at the table — this is standard practice, not a shortcut. Scissors produce a cleaner cut on grilled meat than a knife on a hot grill surface. Keep a clean pair of dedicated BBQ scissors at each table station. Offer to cut for the guest: "Would you like me to cut it?" — most first-timers appreciate this, experienced guests prefer to do it themselves.
- 4

Dwaeji-gimchi-bokkeum end move: When the pork belly is almost finished, scrape the remaining fat and caramelised bits from the grill into a small mound with the last of the kimchi — the rendered pork fat mixed with caramelised kimchi produces an intensely flavourful mixture. Eat this with steamed rice. This "end move" is a known Korean BBQ ritual — guests who know Korean BBQ will do it automatically; introduce it to first-timers as part of the service narrative.

Chef's Tip: Samgyeopsal at 16.0% food cost and \$20.98 contribution margin is your most profitable BBQ item by volume. Every table orders it. Upsell the premium version: "We also have our ibérico pork belly at \$34.99 — the fat marbling is significantly richer and it renders more slowly on the grill." The ibérico upgrade increases the margin per serve by \$8 at minimal cost difference.

- SOYA (ssamjang, kimchi)
- GLUTEN (ssamjang)
- SESAME
- FISH (fish sauce in kimchi)

Bulgogi — Marinated Beef (Table Grill or Kitchen)

Thinly sliced ribeye, Korean pear marinade, onion, spring onion · Sell: \$29.99

5 min grill BBQ Main FC 24%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 200G)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Ribeye or sirloin (thinly sliced, 3–4mm)	200g	\$5.20
Bulgogi marinade (soy, sesame oil, sugar, garlic, ginger, Korean pear/apple)	60ml	\$0.38
Onion (sliced, marinated with beef)	40g	\$0.06
Spring onion, sesame seeds (garnish)	10g	\$0.06
Steamed rice (side)	180g cooked	\$0.22

Total cost per serve \$5.92

Cost per serve	\$5.92
Sell price	\$29.99
Food cost %	19.7%
Contribution margin	\$24.07

- 1

Korean pear is the enzyme tenderiser: The marinade must include grated Korean pear (or Asian pear, or apple as a substitute) — the natural enzymes (bromelain-like proteases) break down muscle fibres and tenderise the beef in 2–4 hours. This is why bulgogi has a distinctive tender-almost-melting texture that no amount of cooking technique replicates without proper marination. Marinate minimum 2 hours, maximum 12 hours — beyond 12 hours the enzymes begin to break down the meat too aggressively, producing a mushy texture.
- 2

High heat, fast cook — do not stew: Bulgogi must be cooked on high heat rapidly. The thin slices and sugar in the marinade caramelize in 2–3 minutes on a very hot grill or cast iron pan. The mistake is cooking bulgogi on medium heat in its own marinade liquid — this produces a boiled, grey, textureless result. High heat, small batches, caramelised edges, residual pink interior. The caramelised marinade creates the characteristic glossy, sweet-savoury coating.
- 3

Table grill vs kitchen preparation: Bulgogi can be grilled at the table (interactive, theatrical) or prepared in the kitchen on a high-heat cast iron (faster service, consistent result). For a busy Saturday service with limited table grill capacity, kitchen-prepared bulgogi served in a hot stone bowl maintains quality without grill congestion. Offer both options at ordering: "We can do this on your table grill or prepared in the kitchen in a stone bowl — which do you prefer?"

Chef's Tip: Bulgogi is Korea's most internationally famous dish and your most recognisable menu item for first-time Korean BBQ guests. The pear enzyme tenderisation technique, properly explained, communicates the depth of Korean culinary science. "We marinate it with Korean pear — the natural enzymes tenderise the beef" is a single sentence that increases perceived value significantly.

GLUTEN (soy) SOYA SESAME

Galbi — Korean Short Rib (Table Grill)

Flanken-cut beef short rib, galbi marinade, table-grilled · Sell: \$34.99 / 250g

8 min grill

Premium BBQ

FC 26%

Premium

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 250G FLANKEN CUT)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef short rib (flanken/LA cut — cross-cut thin)	250g	\$7.25
Galbi marinade (soy, pear, sesame, garlic, ginger, sugar, mirin)	80ml	\$0.45
Ssam wraps (perilla + lettuce)	6 leaves each	\$0.48
Ssamjang, sesame oil salt dip	30g	\$0.28
Total cost per serve		\$8.46
Cost per serve		\$8.46
Sell price		\$34.99
Food cost %		24.2%
Contribution margin		\$26.53

- 1

LA-cut (flanken) is the standard: Galbi means "rib" in Korean. The LA-cut (also called flanken cut) slices the short rib across the bones — producing thin strips with 3–4 small cross-sections of bone. This cut is unique to Korean-American BBQ (developed in the LA Korean community, hence "LA galbi") and is now considered the classic preparation. The thin cut allows rapid grilling while the bone provides flavour and structural interest. Source from a butcher who understands the cut — many standard butchers require special ordering.
- 2

Overnight marinade minimum: The galbi marinade (soy, grated Korean pear, sesame oil, garlic, ginger, sugar, mirin) requires minimum 12 hours — preferably 24. The short rib has more connective tissue than brisket or belly, and the longer marinade time allows the enzymes and salt to penetrate fully. Galbi marinated for less than 12 hours tastes underdeveloped. Batch marinate 48 hours ahead for best results — the flavour deepens significantly.
- 3

Grill over high heat — the bone guides timing: The bone cross-sections act as natural heat sinks — the meat adjacent to the bone takes slightly longer to cook than the meat between bones. Grill 3–4 minutes per side. The meat should be caramelised and slightly charred at the edges, with a blush of pink at the centre. The fat around the bone renders completely and bastes the meat. Cut between bones with scissors to serve — each bone-in piece is one bite.

Chef's Tip: Galbi at \$34.99 with a \$26.53 contribution margin is your premium anchor — the item that signals your restaurant is serious. When a knowledgeable Korean food guest sees LA galbi on the menu at the correct price point, properly described, it communicates immediately that the kitchen understands Korean BBQ at depth. Never discount galbi. Its price is part of its message.

GLUTEN (soy, mirin)

SOYA

SESAME

Dak Galbi — Spicy Stir-Fried Chicken (Table Skillet)

Marinated chicken thigh, gochujang, tteok, cabbage, sweet potato, mozzarella option · Sell: \$22.99

12 min

BBQ / Skillet Main

FC 20%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 2 PERSONS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (boneless, bite-sized)	250g	\$1.77
Gochujang marinade (gochujang, soy, sesame, garlic, ginger, sugar)	60g	\$0.42
Garae-tteok (rice cakes)	100g	\$0.40
Napa cabbage, sweet potato, onion, spring onion	150g	\$0.38
Perilla leaves (finish)	6 leaves	\$0.18
Mozzarella option (+\$3)	60g	\$0.48
Total cost per serve		\$3.63
Cost per serve		\$3.63
Sell price		\$22.99
Food cost %		15.8%
Contribution margin		\$19.36

- 1

Marinate minimum 4 hours: The gochujang marinade penetrates chicken thigh deeply over 4+ hours — the result is a fiery, deeply flavoured interior, not just a surface coating. The gochujang also helps caramelise the chicken during cooking. For the US market, moderate the heat: offer "regular" (2 tbsp gochujang) and "spicy" (4 tbsp). "Spicy" in Korean cuisine is genuinely hot — brief guests accurately rather than apologetically.
- 2

Cast iron skillet or flat-bottomed dolsot: Dak galbi originates from Chuncheon, Korea, and is traditionally cooked on a large flat griddle at the table. A cast iron skillet on a table burner replicates this perfectly. Cook chicken first (3 minutes), add vegetables (2 minutes), add rice cakes (3 minutes), add perilla last. The layered addition timing preserves individual textures — everything added at once produces uneven cooking.
- 3

The mozzarella upsell — cheese dak galbi: Cheese dak galbi () is a viral Korean food trend that has driven massive social media content globally. Offer mozzarella as an add-on (+\$3): "For \$3 more we can add melted mozzarella on top — it's a very popular Korean food trend, great for photos." The visual of stretchy melted cheese pulled from a red spicy skillet is one of the most shared food moments on Instagram. Nearly every table with a guest under 35 will take the upgrade.

Chef's Tip: Dak galbi with the cheese option generates the most social media content of any dish on your menu. Budget the \$3 mozzarella add-on into your food cost expectations — accept that most tables will take it, price accordingly. The Instagram posts from the cheese pull are worth far more than the \$3 margin reduction. Train staff to suggest it proactively every single order.

GLUTEN (gochujang, soy)

SOYA

SESAME

DAIRY (mozzarella option)

Doenjang Jjigae — Fermented Soybean Stew

Aged doenjang, tofu, courgette, mushroom, anchovy dashi, steamed rice · Sell: \$14.99

15 min

Kitchen Main

FC 14%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Doenjang (aged Korean fermented soybean paste, 2-3 yr)	45g	\$0.38
Firm tofu (cubed)	100g	\$0.32
Courgette (zucchini, sliced)	60g	\$0.18
Shiitake mushrooms	40g	\$0.30
Anchovy-kelp dashi (base)	300ml	\$0.32
Onion, garlic, green chilli	30g	\$0.08
Steamed rice	180g cooked	\$0.22

Total cost per serve	\$1.80
Cost per serve	\$1.80
Sell price	\$14.99
Food cost %	12.0%
Contribution margin	\$13.19

- 1

Doenjang quality determines everything: Doenjang is Korean fermented soybean paste — the Korean equivalent of Japanese miso, but longer-aged, deeper, more pungent, and more complex. The quality of your doenjang defines the stew. Source aged doenjang (2-3 years) from a Korean grocery — it is darker, more intensely flavoured, and has a depth that young doenjang lacks. Never substitute Japanese miso — the flavour profile is genuinely different and experienced Korean guests will notice immediately.
- 2

Never boil doenjang: Like Japanese miso, doenjang contains live cultures and delicate volatile aromatics destroyed by boiling. Build the stew: sauté garlic in sesame oil, add dashi, bring to a gentle simmer, add vegetables and tofu, then whisk in doenjang off direct heat. The stew should simmer gently after incorporation — not boil. The bitterness that Korean guests sometimes complain about in restaurant doenjang jjigae is caused by boiling.
- 3

Serve in a hot dolsot — it should still be simmering at the table: Doenjang jjigae served in a hot stone pot that continues to simmer at the table is the standard. The guest stirs the stew gently as it cools — eating progressively as the temperature becomes comfortable. This interactive cooling process is part of the experience. Never serve doenjang jjigae in a cold bowl — it communicates that the kitchen doesn't understand the dish.

Chef's Tip: Doenjang jjigae at 12% food cost is your highest-margin kitchen main. It is also the dish that Korean guests will judge your restaurant by most harshly — it is their home comfort food, and they know exactly what it should taste like. Make it with aged doenjang, proper anchovy dashi, and serve it simmering hot. Get this dish right and you will earn the deep loyalty of your Korean customer base.

SOYA (doenjang, tofu)

FISH (anchovy dashi)

GLUTEN (doenjang may contain wheat)

Bibimbap — Mixed Rice Bowl

Steamed rice, five namul vegetables, beef, fried egg, gochujang, sesame oil · Sell: \$17.99

10 min

Kitchen Main

FC 18%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — DOLSOT VERSION)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Steamed short-grain rice	200g cooked	\$0.25
Beef mince (sautéed, seasoned with soy/sesame)	80g	\$0.55
Five namul (spinach, bean sprout, carrot, mushroom, courgette)	150g combined	\$0.62
Fried egg (sunny-side up)	1 egg	\$0.35
Gochujang (tableside)	25g	\$0.18
Sesame oil drizzle, sesame seeds, nori strips	5ml	\$0.10
Stone pot (dolsot) heating	—	\$0.14

Total cost per serve \$2.19

Cost per serve	\$2.19
Sell price	\$17.99
Food cost %	12.2%
Contribution margin	\$15.80

- 1**Dolsot bibimbap — the crispy rice base:** Heat the empty stone pot until smoking. Add sesame oil, then add the cooked rice — it will sizzle aggressively. Press the rice gently against the sides. Add namul, beef, and egg on top. The bottom of the rice is now forming a crispy, golden crust (nurungji) — this is the signature of dolsot bibimbap. The guest mixes everything tableside, scraping the crispy rice up into the mix. This crust is as important as any topping.
- 2**Five namul — the visual standard:** The five namul (spinach, bean sprouts, carrot, mushroom, courgette) must be arranged in separate sections around the rice like the spokes of a wheel — each colour distinct, portions equal. This presentation communicates balance (both visual and nutritional) and is the classical bibimbap arrangement. A mixed, haphazard arrangement looks sloppy and signals a kitchen that doesn't respect the dish.
- 3**Gochujang — mix tableside, not pre-mixed:** The gochujang must arrive on top of the bowl unmixed, or in a separate small dish. The guest mixes it in themselves — this is both a cultural ritual and a practical heat-control mechanism (they add as much or as little as they want). Serving pre-mixed bibimbap is incorrect and removes the guest's agency. Brief first-timers: "Mix everything together — the heat level is up to you."

Chef's Tip: Bibimbap at 12.2% food cost is your best-margin kitchen main. It also serves as your best vegetarian main (substitute mushroom or tofu for beef). The dolsot version at \$17.99 vs a regular bowl at \$14.99 — always guide guests toward the dolsot: "The stone bowl version gives you the crispy rice at the bottom — it's definitely worth the extra \$3." Conversion rate on this upsell is extremely high.

GLUTEN (soy, gochujang)

SOYA

SESAME

EGGS

Kimchi Jjigae — Kimchi Stew with Pork

Aged kimchi, pork belly, tofu, anchovy dashi, steamed rice · Sell: \$15.99

15 min Kitchen Main FC 16%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Aged kimchi (minimum 2 weeks fermented — the sourer the better)	150g	\$0.48
Pork belly (cubed, for stewing)	100g	\$1.35
Firm tofu (cubed)	100g	\$0.32
Anchovy-kelp dashi	250ml	\$0.28
Kimchi juice (from the kimchi jar — liquid gold)	40ml	\$0.00
Gochugaru, garlic, sesame oil	15g	\$0.12
Steamed rice	180g cooked	\$0.22

Total cost per serve \$2.77

Cost per serve	\$2.77
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	17.3%
Contribution margin	\$13.22

- 1

Old kimchi only — the sourer the better: Kimchi jjigae made with fresh kimchi is flat and thin. The dish requires over-fermented kimchi (mukimchi) — the intensely sour, deeply funky kimchi that would be unpleasant to eat as a side dish becomes magnificent in a braise. This is why Korean kitchens actively rotate their oldest, sourest kimchi into jjigae rather than discarding it. Your kimchi jjigae improves as your house kimchi ages — this is a restaurant that gets better over time.
- 2

Render the pork belly first: Cut pork belly into 2cm cubes. Render in a dry pot until the fat is partially released and the exterior begins to brown — this takes 4-5 minutes. The rendered pork fat then becomes the cooking medium for the kimchi and aromatics, adding depth and richness impossible to achieve by adding pork and liquid simultaneously. Deglaze with kimchi juice (never waste it — it contains all the fermentation's concentrated flavour) then add dashi and kimchi.
- 3

Simmer 20 minutes minimum: Kimchi jjigae requires time — the kimchi softens, the pork belly becomes tender, and the flavours meld into a unified, deeply savoury broth. A rushed kimchi jjigae has harsh, disjointed flavours. Add the tofu in the last 5 minutes only — it breaks down if cooked too long. Serve simmering in the dolsot, rice on the side. The guest eats the stew with spoonfuls of plain rice — the contrast of plain rice against the intensely flavoured broth is fundamental.

Chef's Tip: Kimchi jjigae is the dish Korean people eat when they are homesick. When you make it correctly — aged kimchi, rendered pork, proper dashi — Korean guests will notice immediately and tell other Korean guests. Word-of-mouth within the Korean community is the most valuable marketing you cannot buy. Make this dish with complete authenticity.

SOYA (kimchi, tofu) FISH (anchovy dashi, fish sauce in kimchi)
GLUTEN (may be in kimchi brand)

Naengmyeon — Cold Buckwheat Noodles

Buckwheat noodles, chilled dongchimi broth, sliced beef, pickled radish, cucumber, mustard, vinegar · Sell: \$16.99

8 min Kitchen Main FC 17%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Naengmyeon noodles (buckwheat, chewy)	130g dry	\$0.58
Dongchimi broth (radish water kimchi, chilled)	300ml	\$0.42
Sliced beef brisket (boiled, chilled)	60g	\$1.10
Cucumber (julienne), pickled radish, pear slices	80g	\$0.38
Hard-boiled egg (halved)	1/2 egg	\$0.18
Korean mustard, rice vinegar (tableside)	10g	\$0.08
Ice (broth served over ice)	—	\$0.04

Total cost per serve \$2.78

Cost per serve	\$2.78
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	16.4%
Contribution margin	\$14.21

1 Naengmyeon is the perfect palate cleanser after BBQ: Cold buckwheat noodles in an icy, refreshing broth after the rich, smoky, fatty Korean BBQ experience is one of the great meal progressions in world cuisine. Train servers to suggest naengmyeon proactively toward the end of the BBQ courses: "Many guests like to finish with cold noodles after the grill — it's very refreshing. Would you like to try?" This suggestion has a very high conversion rate because the guest is typically experiencing mild heat and richness fatigue at that point.

2 Dongchimi broth must be ice cold: Dongchimi (radish water kimchi) produces a clear, mildly sour, refreshingly light broth. Keep it refrigerated at **2°C / 36°F** and serve over ice in the bowl. The broth should be almost uncomfortably cold — this temperature contrast after hot grilled meat is the entire point of the dish. Warm naengmyeon broth is incorrect and defeats the purpose.

3 Noodle texture — resistant chew: Naengmyeon noodles have an intensely chewy, springy texture unlike any Western noodle. They are notoriously difficult to cut with chopsticks — Korean restaurants provide scissors to cut them at the table. Boil 3–4 minutes, rinse in ice water aggressively until very cold, drain completely. The noodles should be served ice cold in the bowl — never room temperature.

Chef's Tip: Naengmyeon is your most culturally distinctive dish — guests who have never experienced Korean cold noodles will remember it long after they've forgotten what they grilled. The mustard and vinegar are added tableside to adjust sourness and heat — brief the guest on both: "Korean mustard is stronger than Western — start with a little." This education creates a memorable, considered moment in the meal.

GLUTEN (buckwheat noodles may contain wheat — check brand) EGGS
GLUTEN-FREE: use 100% buckwheat variety

Galbi Jjim — Braised Short Rib (Kitchen Special)

Slow-braised beef short rib, soy-pear-sesame braise, daikon, carrot, steamed rice · Sell: \$29.99

3 min plating

Kitchen Special

FC 24%

Weekend Only

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 300G BRAISE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef short rib (English cut, bone-in, 300g)	300g raw / 200g cooked	\$5.40
Braising liquid (soy, pear juice, sesame oil, garlic, ginger, mirin, sugar)	300ml	\$0.68
Daikon (large cubes, braised in same liquid)	80g	\$0.12
Carrot (large cubes)	60g	\$0.08
Shiitake mushrooms (whole, braised)	40g	\$0.30
Steamed rice, spring onion, pine nuts	180g rice	\$0.38
Total cost per serve		\$6.96
Cost per serve		\$6.96
Sell price		\$29.99
Food cost %		23.2%
Contribution margin		\$23.03

- 1

Blanch first — always: Cover short ribs in cold water, bring to boil, discard the grey scum-filled water. Rinse the ribs. This blanching step removes blood and bone fragments that would cloud the braise and produce a bitter, harsh flavour. The braising liquid built after blanching is clear, clean, and deeply savoury. Every galbi jjim that tastes "off" was made without blanching.
- 2

Low and slow — 2.5 hours minimum: Braise at

150°C / 302°F

 covered for 2.5 hours. The collagen in the short rib converts to gelatin, the braising liquid reduces and thickens, and the meat becomes fall-off-the-bone tender while retaining its shape. Add daikon and carrot in the last 45 minutes — they absorb the braising liquid and become deeply flavourful without turning to mush. Add mushrooms in the last 20 minutes.
- 3

Batch braise — serve as weekend special: Galbi jjim is a 3-hour production that is impractical to make à la minute. Braise large batches (10–12 portions) on Thursday/Friday, refrigerate overnight — the fat solidifies and can be skimmed cleanly, and the flavours deepen significantly. Reheat to order: 8 minutes in the braising liquid in a covered pan. Position as a weekend special: "Our galbi jjim is our weekend slow-braise — we make it on Fridays, it's usually sold out by Saturday night."

Chef's Tip: Galbi jjim is your most technically impressive kitchen dish and the one that most clearly communicates that your kitchen is serious. The deeply lacquered, falling-off-the-bone rib in its own reduced glaze, surrounded by root vegetables that have absorbed the braising liquid — this is Korean celebration food. Positioning it as a limited weekend special creates demand and scarcity. Sell out consistently to reinforce this.

GLUTEN (soy, mirin)

SOYA

SESAME

NUTS (pine nuts)

3 DESSERTS

Bingsu — Korean Shaved Ice

Milk shaved ice, sweet red bean, mochi, condensed milk, seasonal fruit · Sell: \$11.99

5 min

Dessert

FC 14%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Milk ice block (frozen milk, shaved to snow consistency)	250g	\$0.35
Patbingsu red bean paste (sweetened azuki)	80g	\$0.38
Mochi pieces (bite-sized, store-bought or house-made)	40g	\$0.32
Condensed milk (drizzle)	20ml	\$0.12
Fresh seasonal fruit (strawberry, mango, or peach)	60g	\$0.38
Injeolmi (roasted rice cake powder, optional premium)	10g	\$0.14
Total cost per serve		\$1.69

Cost per serve	\$1.69
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	14.1%
Contribution margin	\$10.30

- 1

Milk ice — not water ice: Authentic bingsu uses blocks of frozen milk (full-fat, sometimes sweetened with sugar and vanilla) rather than plain ice — this produces a softer, creamier, snow-like texture when shaved. Freeze milk in small rectangular containers (500ml). Shave directly from the frozen block using a commercial shaved ice machine or a powerful snow cone machine. The result should resemble fresh snow — not ice chips or slush. The machine investment (\$200-400) is essential.
- 2

Build height and volume: Bingsu's visual signature is its towering volume — a generous mound of milk ice rising well above the bowl, topped with toppings. A flat, sparse bingsu looks like an afterthought. The standard presentation: bowl, generous milk ice mound rising 8-10cm above the bowl rim, red bean on top, mochi scattered, condensed milk drizzled, fresh fruit arranged. This generous portion is why bingsu commands \$11.99 for what is essentially shaved milk and beans.
- 3

Serve immediately — it melts in 8 minutes: Milk bingsu begins to melt the moment it leaves the machine. Prepare and deliver to the table within 3 minutes. Brief the guest: "This is best eaten quickly — it melts fast." The sense of urgency is part of the experience and mirrors the street food culture of Korean patbingsu vendors. Never plate bingsu ahead of service — make it live, serve immediately.

***Chef's Tip:** Bingsu is your most viral dessert — the towering presentation photographs magnificently and has driven millions of social media posts for Korean restaurants globally. At 14.1% food cost, it is excellent margin. The seasonal fruit variation (strawberry bingsu in summer, mango in autumn) gives you a reason to post new content and change your menu photography regularly. Offer an injeolmi (roasted soybean powder) version for the more adventurous guest — it has a nutty, toasty flavour unlike anything in Western desserts.*

DAIRY (milk, condensed milk)

GLUTEN-FREE ✓ (check mochi brand)

Hotteok — Sweet Filled Pancake

Chewy yeasted pancake, brown sugar cinnamon walnut filling, crispy exterior · Sell: \$7.99

8 min

Dessert

FC 10%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 2 PANCAKES)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Hotteok dough (flour, yeast, sugar, milk, salt — rested 1hr)	120g dough	\$0.18
Brown sugar filling (dark brown sugar, cinnamon, crushed walnuts)	30g	\$0.22
Vegetable oil (frying)	—	\$0.04
Vanilla ice cream (scoop, side)	60g	\$0.28
Toasted sesame seeds (garnish)	1g	\$0.02

Total cost per serve \$0.74

Cost per serve	\$0.74
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	9.3%
Contribution margin	\$7.25

- 1

Yeast dough — rest is essential: Hotteok dough is a simple yeasted dough — flour, instant yeast, sugar, salt, warm milk. Rest 1 hour at room temperature covered. The yeast fermentation creates the slightly chewy, mildly tangy interior that distinguishes hotteok from a plain pancake. Under-rested dough produces a dense, heavy pancake without the characteristic chew. Batch the dough morning and afternoon — it holds well in the refrigerator after the first rise for up to 8 hours.
- 2

Filling and forming: Portion dough into 60g balls. Flatten in your palm, place 15g of brown sugar-cinnamon-walnut filling in the centre, fold the dough up around the filling and pinch to seal completely. Any unsealed dough allows the sugar to escape during frying — it burns on the pan and the pancake loses its molten interior. Press the formed ball flat (about 1cm thick) immediately before placing in the pan.
- 3

Press with a hotteok press or flat spatula: Place the filled ball flat-side down in a lightly oiled pan over medium heat. Immediately press flat with a hotteok press (a wooden or metal pressing tool) or the flat side of a wide spatula — pressing to approximately 8mm thickness. Cook 3 minutes until deep golden, flip, press again, cook 2 more minutes. The sugar filling liquefies completely during cooking — the interior should be molten when bitten.

Chef's Tip: Hotteok at 9.3% food cost is your most profitable dessert and the dish most likely to convert first-time Korean food guests into regulars. The molten brown sugar interior is genuinely surprising and delightful — most guests have no reference point for it. Served with a scoop of vanilla ice cream, the contrast of hot-crispy-sweet pancake against cold cream is exceptional. Brief servers to sell it proactively at dessert: "Our hotteok is a Korean street food classic — crispy outside, molten brown sugar inside. Most people order two."

GLUTEN (flour)

DAIRY (milk, ice cream)

NUTS (walnuts)

SESAME

Sikhye — Sweet Rice Punch

Traditional fermented rice drink, pine nuts, honey, served chilled · Sell: \$5.99

2 min

Dessert Drink

FC 8%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Sikhye (batch — malt water, cooked rice, ginger, sugar)	250ml	\$0.28
Pine nuts (float on top)	3g	\$0.12
Ice	—	\$0.02
Jujube slice (garnish, optional)	1 slice	\$0.05
Total cost per serve		\$0.47
Cost per serve		\$0.47
Sell price		\$5.99
Food cost %		7.8%
Contribution margin		\$5.52

- 1

Sikhye is the traditional Korean meal-ender: Sikhye is a mildly sweet, lightly fermented rice punch — served ice cold after a Korean meal as a digestive. The starch enzymes in the malt water partially break down the rice, producing a mildly sweet, slightly effervescent drink with floating cooked rice grains. It is one of the oldest traditional Korean beverages, served at formal celebrations and everyday meals alike. Commercially produced sikhye is available at Korean grocers — a good commercial version is acceptable.
- 2

Serve in a small bowl or glass with pine nuts floating on top: Three pine nuts floating on the surface is the traditional presentation — they add a subtle nutty fragrance as the guest drinks. Serve very cold. Brief the guest: "This is sikhye — a traditional Korean rice punch. It's mildly sweet and very refreshing after the grill. It's how Korean meals traditionally end." This context transforms a \$0.47-cost drink into a cultural moment worth \$5.99.

Chef's Tip: Sikhye at 7.8% food cost is your highest-margin item on the entire menu. Position it as the traditional Korean meal finale — suggest it proactively at the end of every BBQ meal. "In Korea, meals traditionally end with sikhye — would you like to try it?" The cultural framing, the beautiful presentation, and the genuinely refreshing flavour make it an easy yes. A table of 4 ordering sikhye generates \$23.96 revenue at \$1.88 cost.

GLUTEN-FREE ✓

NUTS (pine nuts)

VEGAN ✓

Yakgwa — Honey Ginger Cookie

Traditional fried honey cookies, ginger, sesame oil, cinnamon, served with green tea · Sell: \$8.99

3 min

Dessert

FC 9%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVE — 4 COOKIES + GREEN TEA)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Yakgwa cookies (batch baked — flour, sesame oil, honey, ginger, cinnamon, soju)	4 cookies / 80g	\$0.38
Honey glaze (brush after frying)	10ml	\$0.08
Korean green tea (boricha or nokcha, brewed)	200ml	\$0.12
Edible flower or pine nut garnish	2g	\$0.08
Powdered cinnamon (dust)	0.5g	\$0.01

Total cost per serve \$0.67

Cost per serve	\$0.67
Sell price	\$8.99
Food cost %	7.5%
Contribution margin	\$8.32

- 1

Yakgwa technique — fry then soak in honey: Yakgwa dough is mixed with sesame oil, honey, ginger juice, cinnamon, and a small amount of soju (the soju helps create a flaky texture). Rolled, cut into flower shapes or rectangles, deep-fried at 150°C / 302°F for 6–8 minutes until golden. Then immediately soaked in warm honey syrup (honey + ginger + cinnamon) for 30 minutes — the cookies absorb the honey and become moist, fragrant, and deeply flavoured. The soaking step is non-negotiable.
- 2

Batch produce weekly — they improve over time: Yakgwa stores well at room temperature in an airtight container for 1 week. The flavour deepens as the honey and spices continue to permeate. Make a large batch on Mondays — by Friday the cookies are at their best. This is the same logic as aged kimchi: Korean cuisine often improves with time, and your kitchen should embrace this principle across multiple items.
- 3

Pair with Korean green tea — position as the ceremonial close: Boricha (roasted barley tea) or nokcha (green tea) alongside yakgwa is the Korean version of petit fours with coffee. The slight bitterness of the tea balances the sweetness of the honey cookies. Position this pairing as the ceremonial close of the Korean BBQ meal: "This is how we traditionally end the meal in Korea — honey cookies and tea." The ritual close gives the meal a beginning, middle, and definitive end.

Chef's Tip: Yakgwa at 7.5% food cost is your second-highest margin item. It is also the most culturally distinctive dessert on your menu — few non-Korean guests have ever encountered it. The combination of fried dough, honey, sesame, ginger, and cinnamon is genuinely unique and memorable. Your dessert menu should end with this dish — it provides the most appropriate and elegant close to the Korean BBQ experience.

GLUTEN (flour)

SESAME

ALCOHOL (soju — trace amounts, burns off in frying)

4 DRINKS MENU

Soju — Korean Spirit Service

Chilled Jinro soju, shot service or as mixer · Sell: \$6.99 per shot / \$18.99 per bottle

Spirit FC 18% Volume Driver

PER BOTTLE SERVICE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Jinro soju (360ml bottle, 16.9% ABV)	1 bottle	\$3.20
Shot glasses (2, chilled)	2	\$0.10
Ice bucket (optional, for chilling)	—	\$0.05

Total cost per bottle \$3.35

Cost per bottle	\$3.35
Sell price	\$18.99
Food cost %	17.6%
Contribution margin	\$15.64

- 1

Soju is your highest-volume drinks item: At a Korean BBQ table, soju bottles move fast. A table of 4 friends on a Friday night will consume 3-5 bottles of soju over the course of the evening. At \$18.99 per bottle with \$15.64 contribution margin, five bottles generates \$78.20 drinks revenue from one table. Your drinks revenue at a Korean BBQ is potentially equal to or greater than your food revenue — manage it accordingly.
- 2

Korean drinking etiquette — the service moment: In Korean culture, you pour for others, not for yourself. The server should demonstrate this at the first bottle: "In Korean culture, you pour for each other — it's considered a sign of respect." This cultural moment is memorable and creates connection. Offer to pour the first round — "Allow me." Then let the table take over. Brief all servers on Korean drinking rituals — it transforms a transaction into an experience.
- 3

The somaek (soju bomb) upsell: Somaek is soju dropped into a glass of Korean beer — Korea's most popular drink combination. Offer it proactively: "Have you tried somaek? It's soju dropped into beer — Korea's most popular drink. Very refreshing with the BBQ." At \$6.99 soju + \$7.99 beer = \$14.98 combined, the somaek conversation drives both drinks categories simultaneously. Train every server to offer it once per table.

ALCOHOL (16.9% ABV) GLUTEN-FREE ✓

Makgeolli — Korean Rice Wine

Traditional unfiltered rice wine, served in a bowl · Sell: \$9.99 per bowl / \$22.99 per kettle

Rice Wine

FC 16%

PER KETTLE SERVICE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Makgeolli (750ml kettle, 6-8% ABV, milky)	1 kettle	\$3.50
Makgeolli bowls (traditional ceramic, 2)	2	\$0.10
Total cost per kettle		\$3.60
Cost per kettle		\$3.60
Sell price		\$22.99
Food cost %		15.7%
Contribution margin		\$19.39

- 1

Shake before serving: Makgeolli is unfiltered — the rice sediment settles to the bottom. Always shake the bottle gently before pouring. Serve in shallow ceramic bowls, not glasses — this is the traditional vessel and the wide surface area allows the natural carbonation to develop as the guest drinks. Brief non-Korean guests: "Makgeolli is Korean rice wine — it's lightly sparkling, mildly sweet, about 6-7% alcohol. Think of it like a milky, refreshing beer." This description removes hesitation and drives orders.
- 2

Makgeolli pairs exceptionally well with pajeon: The classic Korean pairing is makgeolli and pajeon — rice wine and seafood pancake. This pairing is culturally embedded (traditionally consumed together on rainy days in Korea). Position it as a pairing: "Our haemul pajeon pairs perfectly with makgeolli — it's a classic Korean combination." This pairing suggestion drives both items simultaneously and demonstrates cultural knowledge.

ALCOHOL (6-8% ABV)

GLUTEN-FREE ✓ (pure rice — check brand)

Cass or OB Beer — Korean Draft Lager

Korean lager on draught or bottle · Sell: \$7.99

Beer FC 18%

PER SERVE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Cass or OB (Korean lager, 330ml bottle or 400ml draught)	1 serve	\$1.35
Glass (branded if draught)	—	\$0.10
Total cost		\$1.45
Cost per serve		\$1.45
Sell price		\$7.99
Food cost %		18.1%
Contribution margin		\$6.54

- 1

Korean beer identity matters: Cass and OB are the dominant Korean beer brands — light, crisp, clean lagers designed to complement grilled food without competing. Serving Budweiser or Heineken at a Korean BBQ misses the cultural alignment. Guests who know Korean BBQ will appreciate seeing Korean brands; guests who don't will appreciate the education. "This is Cass — Korea's most popular beer. Very clean and light, perfect for cutting through the BBQ richness."
- 2

The somaek bomb: Drop a shot of soju into a full glass of Korean beer — this is somaek, Korea's most popular drink. The combination produces a slightly stronger, more complex drink than either alone. Some guests enjoy the ritual of making it themselves — have a shot glass of soju ready alongside the beer. "Would you like to make a somaek? Drop the shot glass into the beer and drink before it mixes." This is entertaining, shareable, and drives dual-item orders.

ALCOHOL GLUTEN (barley)

Yujacha — Yuzu Citron Tea

Korean yuja marmalade, hot water, honey, lemon · Sell: \$5.99

Non-Alcoholic FC 9%

PER SERVE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Yuja-cheong (yuzu citron marmalade, Korean brand)	2 tbsp / 40g	\$0.38
Hot water	200ml	\$0.00
Honey drizzle	5ml	\$0.05
Lemon slice garnish	1 slice	\$0.04
Total cost		\$0.47
Cost per serve		\$0.47
Sell price		\$5.99
Food cost %		7.8%
Contribution margin		\$5.52

- 1 Stir 2 tablespoons of yuja-cheong (Korean yuzu citron marmalade — sold at all Korean grocers) into a cup of hot water. The marmalade dissolves partially, leaving small pieces of citron peel. Add a drizzle of honey and a lemon slice. Yujacha is Korea's most popular hot beverage after coffee — warming, citrusy, mildly sweet, and deeply comforting. Perfect for non-drinkers and for the colder months.

GLUTEN-FREE ✓ VEGAN ✓ (omit honey for strict vegan)

Banana Milk — Bing Grre Iconic Drink

Korean banana milk (Binggrae), served cold, nostalgic packaging · Sell: \$4.99

Non-Alcoholic FC 14%

PER SERVE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Binggrae banana milk (original iconic bottle)	240ml	\$0.65
Total cost		\$0.65
Cost per serve		\$0.65
Sell price		\$4.99
Food cost %		13.0%
Contribution margin		\$4.34

- 1 Binggrae banana milk in its iconic barrel-shaped bottle is one of the most recognised packaged foods in Korea — it has been sold unchanged since 1974 and is a powerful nostalgia trigger for Korean guests and a curiosity trigger for non-Korean guests. Serve it straight from refrigeration. No preparation required — the product IS the experience. Brief guests: "This is Korea's most iconic drink — the bottle design hasn't changed since 1974." The history creates the moment.

DAIRY (milk) GLUTEN-FREE ✓

Korean Iced Coffee — Dalgona Style

Whipped instant coffee foam, cold oat milk, ice · Sell: \$6.99

Non-Alcoholic FC 10%

PER SERVE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Instant coffee (2 tbsp, whipped with equal sugar + hot water)	10g	\$0.12
Oat milk (cold)	200ml	\$0.52
Ice	—	\$0.02
Cocoa powder dust (optional)	0.5g	\$0.02
Total cost		\$0.68
Cost per serve		\$0.68
Sell price		\$6.99
Food cost %		9.7%
Contribution margin		\$6.31

- 1 Dalgona coffee went globally viral on TikTok in 2020 and is still widely recognised. Whip 2 tbsp instant coffee, 2 tbsp sugar, and 2 tbsp hot water with an electric mixer for 3–4 minutes until thick, caramel-coloured foam forms. Spoon over cold oat milk and ice. The guest stirs it themselves — the mixing is part of the experience and creates an Instagram-worthy transition from two-toned to uniform coffee colour.
- 2 Dalgona coffee is a strong signal to younger guests (25–35) that your restaurant is culturally current. It requires minimal equipment, uses pantry ingredients, and generates social media content reliably. Always batch the whipped coffee foam in small quantities (not more than 30 minutes ahead) — it deflates over time and loses its signature thick texture.

DAIRY-FREE ✓ (oat milk) GLUTEN-FREE ✓ CAFFEINE: high

Omija Sparkling — Five Flavour Berry Shrub

Omija (schisandra berry) syrup, sparkling water, lime · Sell: \$6.99

Non-Alcoholic FC 8%

PER SERVE

ITEM	AMOUNT	COST
Omija (schisandra berry) syrup — batch infused	40ml	\$0.30
Sparkling water	150ml	\$0.10
Fresh lime juice	10ml	\$0.06
Ice, lime wheel garnish	—	\$0.05
Total cost		\$0.51
Cost per serve		\$0.51
Sell price		\$6.99
Food cost %		7.3%
Contribution margin		\$6.48

1 Omija (schisandra berries) embody all five flavours simultaneously — sweet, sour, salty, bitter, spicy — hence the name "five flavour berry." This complexity in a single ingredient is a perfect metaphor for Korean cuisine's commitment to flavour balance. Steep dried omija berries in hot water 30 minutes, strain, sweeten lightly. The resulting syrup is a vivid red-pink with a genuinely unique, multi-dimensional flavour unlike any Western ingredient. Brief as: "This is made with omija — a Korean berry that contains all five flavours at once. Very unique."

GLUTEN-FREE ✓ VEGAN ✓

5 SERVICE TRAINING MODULE

Korean BBQ Service Philosophy: You are managing an experience, not a meal. Guests need consistent attention — banchan refills, grill management, ssam guidance, drinks pacing. The server-to-table ratio for Korean BBQ must be lower than standard restaurants: maximum 4 tables per server during peak service. Budget for this in your labour cost or your guest experience will suffer.

// TABLE WELCOME & GRILL INTRODUCTION

"Welcome — I'll be with you tonight. Let me get your grill started and bring out your banchan while you look at the menu. Our banchan — the small side dishes — are complimentary and we'll keep them topped up throughout your meal. Have you done Korean BBQ before, or is this your first time?"

Why: Asking about experience level immediately allows the server to calibrate the service narrative. First-timers need full education; experienced guests need minimal instruction. This question unlocks the entire service approach for the table.

// FIRST-TIMER FULL EDUCATION (2 MINUTES, ONCE)

"So at Korean BBQ — everything is designed to share. The meat arrives raw and you grill it on the table. I'll help manage the grill and let you know when things are ready. The fun part is the ssam — you take a piece of meat, put it in a lettuce or perilla leaf with some of the ssamjang paste and a sliver of garlic, and eat it as a wrap. One bite. That's the traditional way. Any questions before we start?"

Why: A clear, enthusiastic 2-minute education at the start prevents 20 minutes of confused questions throughout the meal. Guests who feel informed enjoy the meal more, spend more, and tip better.

// DRINKS OPENING SCRIPT

"For drinks — soju is the classic Korean BBQ pairing. We do it by the bottle at \$18.99 or by the shot. Korean beer goes perfectly with it — and if you want to try a somaek, that's where you drop the soju shot into the beer. Very popular. Or if you prefer not to drink, our omija sparkling is really refreshing — it's made with a Korean berry that has all five flavours simultaneously."

Why: Offering both alcohol and non-alcohol options in the same breath avoids making non-drinkers feel excluded. The somaek mention drives dual-product orders. The omija description is distinctive enough to convert curious non-drinkers.

// GRILL MANAGEMENT LANGUAGE

"Your samgyeopsal needs about 7-8 minutes on each side — when the edges are golden and the fat is rendered, it's ready. I'll change the grill grate halfway through to keep the smoke clean. Would you like me to cut it when it's done, or do you prefer to do it yourselves?"

Why: Proactively communicating timing manages expectations and prevents guests from eating undercooked meat. The scissors question is a personalisation moment — offering the choice shows respect for individual preferences.

// NAENGYEON UPSELL (END OF BBQ COURSES)

"You've done the grill beautifully — would you like to finish with cold noodles? Naengmyeon is the traditional way to end a Korean BBQ meal — buckwheat noodles in a chilled broth, very refreshing after the grill. It's also how Korean people traditionally cleanse the palate. We also have bingsu — Korean shaved milk ice — if you want something lighter."

Why: The post-BBQ meal extension is your highest-margin upsell opportunity. The guest is relaxed, happy, and often still at the table socialising. A well-timed dessert/cold noodle suggestion converts 40-60% of tables to an additional course.

// CLOSING SCRIPT & RETURN DRIVER

"Before you go — we rotate our premium meat specials weekly. This week we had the ibérico samgyeopsal that sold out by Saturday. If you want to know what's coming next week, you can join our text list at the front — we send one message a week, nothing else."

Why: The scarcity narrative (sold out by Saturday) creates urgency and FOMO. The text list is your direct marketing channel — 98% open rate vs 20% for email. Build this list aggressively. 500 subscribers who come twice a month = your stable revenue base.

6 STAFF WORKFLOW — KITCHEN & FLOOR

Korean BBQ staffing reality: This concept operates with a lean kitchen (1 Head Chef + 1 Cook + 1 Kitchen Steward) producing all kitchen dishes, while the BBQ grill component is guest-operated. This division of labour is the economic advantage of the Korean BBQ model — the guest does a significant portion of the "cooking." Your floor team manages the grill, which requires more server time but less kitchen labour than a traditional restaurant.

ROLE

COUNT

PEAK

PRIMARY RESPONSIBILITIES			HOURS
Head Chef	1	All kitchen mains (jjigae, bibimbap, naengmyeon, galbi jjim batch). Quality control on all prep. Banchan production. Menu development. Ordering and receiving. Kitchen training.	10am-2pm prep / 5-10pm service
Line Cook	1	Entrée production (pajeon, tteokbokki, japchae, dakgangjeong). Dessert plating (bingsu, hotteok). Grill prep (slicing meats, portioning). Banchan batching support.	12pm-3pm prep / 5-10pm service
Kitchen Steward	1	Dishwashing. Grill grate cleaning and rotation (critical role). Prep support (peeling, cutting, portioning). Banchan replenishment washing. Kitchen cleaning during and after service.	4pm-11pm (split shifts optional)
Floor Manager / Head Server	1	Table allocation. Grill lighting and management. Banchan service and refills. Drinks ordering and service. Grill grate rotation (coordinate with steward). Guest education for first-timers.	5-10:30pm (full service)
Servers	2-3	Max 4 tables per server. Grill monitoring, meat cutting, ssam guidance. Drinks service and reorders. Banchan refills. Dessert and cold noodle upsell at end of meal.	5-10:30pm (staggered)

KITCHEN WORKFLOW — SERVICE SEQUENCE

TIME	HEAD CHEF	LINE COOK	STEWARD
10:00am	Check stock levels, place orders, begin galbi jjim batch (Fri/Sat)	Day off or PM shift start	Deep clean from previous night
12:00pm	Banchan production — kimchi check, japchae, namul batches	Meat portioning and slicing, banchan support	Receiving deliveries, prep support
3:00pm	Dashi production, doenjang jjigae base, sundubu prep	Pajeon batter, tteokbokki sauce, hotteok dough rest	Grill grate prep (clean + pre-heat spares)
5:00pm	Service ready — kitchen on call for kitchen mains	Entrée station ready — fry setup, pancake station	Dishpit running, grill grate rotation on demand
Service	Calls and plates all kitchen mains within 12 min	All entrées within 10 min, desserts within 5 min	Grill grates every 2-3 tables, continuous wash
10:30pm	Kitchen breakdown, stock check, prep list for next day	Fryer breakdown and filter, station clean	Full kitchen clean, grill grate soak

FLOOR WORKFLOW — TABLE LIFECYCLE (FROM SEATED TO DEPARTED)

TIMING	ACTION	OWNER
0 min (seated)	Light table grill, deliver full banchan set, introduce concept to first-timers	Server
2 min	Take drinks order — lead with soju/somaek/makgeolli suggestion	Server
5 min	Take food order — guide BBQ meats + 1-2 kitchen items + entrée	Server
8 min	Deliver drinks, deliver entrée (pajeon or tteokbokki first)	Server
12 min	Deliver first round BBQ meats (raw, portioned on plate)	Server
15 min	First grill check — cut meat if needed, refill empty banchan	Server
25 min	Grill grate change (coordinate with steward), offer second round meats or kitchen main	Server + Steward
40 min	Reorder drinks, offer second round of soju	Server
55 min	Suggest naengmyeon or bingsu to close — "traditional Korean ending"	Server
70 min	Serve dessert/cold noodles, offer sikhye and yakgwa	Server

7 WEEKLY PREP SCHEDULE

TASK	FREQUENCY	TIME	NOTES
Kimchi batch (baechu kimchi)	Weekly (Mon)	2 hours	5kg batch — ferment 3 days room temp, then refrigerate. Rotate old to jjigae.
Anchovy-kelp dashi	Daily	20 min	Single large batch serves all jjigae, tteokbokki, and sundubu for the day.
Banchan production (all 6)	Daily	90 min	Start with most time-consuming (japchae), then namul, then kimchi check.
Galbi jjim batch	Thu + Fri	3.5 hours	Blanch, braise 2.5hr, cool overnight. Weekend special — max 12 portions.
Meat portioning and slicing	Daily	45 min	Partially freeze brisket for thin slicing. Portion pork belly, ribeye for bulgogi.
Dongchimi broth (naengmyeon)	Twice weekly	30 min + 24hr ferment	Needs 24 hours minimum fermentation. Make Mon + Thu.
Gochujang sauces (tteokbokki, dakgangjeong glaze)	Twice weekly	30 min	Batch and refrigerate — holds 5 days.
Hotteok dough	Daily (AM and PM batches)	10 min + 1hr rest	Two batches — morning and late afternoon. Dough refrigerates well for 8 hours.
Yakgwa cookies	Weekly (Mon)	2 hours	Improves by Friday. Store airtight. 40-piece batch serves 10 dessert orders.
Sikhye	Twice weekly	45 min + cooling	Large batch. Refrigerate immediately. Serve ice cold.
Omija syrup	Weekly	45 min	Steep, strain, sweeten. Holds 2 weeks refrigerated.
Grill grate cleaning	Daily (pre-service + during)	30 min pre + ongoing	Steward role. Soak overnight, scrub morning. 6-8 spare grates minimum.

8 CUSTOMER RETENTION SYSTEM

// THE KOREAN BBQ LOYALTY ARCHITECTURE

Korean BBQ has one of the highest natural return rates of any restaurant format — the experience is inherently group-based and social, which means a satisfied guest brings new guests on return visits. Your single most important retention action is building the text/SMS list. Not Instagram followers. Not email. SMS — because Korean BBQ guests are booking with groups and a weekly special message drives immediate group bookings more effectively than any other channel.

// WEEKLY SPECIALS SMS STRATEGY

Every Thursday: send one SMS to your list. "This weekend: ibérico samgyeopsal + new seasonal bingsu. Friday and Saturday only. Reply BOOK to reserve." That's it. One message, one clear offer, one action. Track how many reservations come from this message. This number is your most important marketing metric.

Why: The limited-availability weekend special creates scarcity and urgency. "Friday and Saturday only" is a deadline. The direct booking reply removes friction. SMS open rates are 98% within 3 minutes of delivery. You will see direct, traceable revenue from this message within hours of sending it.

// THE RETURN DRIVER CONVERSATION

"We do a different premium meat special every week — last week we did wagyu striploin, this week is ibérico pork belly. Next week we're doing a limited Jeju black pork. If you want to know what's coming, just leave your number with us — we send one text per week."

Why: Naming specific upcoming specials creates concrete, tangible reasons to return. "Next week we're doing Jeju black pork" is more powerful than "we have weekly specials." The specific mention makes the guest visualise their next visit. Collect the number at the moment of peak satisfaction — just before they leave, when the meal was excellent and the mood is highest.

9 P&L MODEL — 60-SEAT KOREAN BBQ, US MARKET 2025

REVENUE STREAM	WEEKLY COVERS	AVG SPEND	WEEKLY REVENUE
Dinner service (Tue-Thu)	150 covers	\$62	\$9,300
Dinner service (Fri-Sat)	220 covers	\$72	\$15,840
Lunch (Sat-Sun)	80 covers	\$45	\$3,600
Total Weekly Revenue	450 covers	\$64 avg	\$28,740

COST CATEGORY	% OF REVENUE	WEEKLY AMOUNT	NOTES
Food & beverage cost (blended)	24%	\$6,898	Higher than avg due to premium BBQ meats; drinks offset
Labour — kitchen (3 staff)	12%	\$3,449	Head Chef \$65K, Cook \$45K, Steward \$35K annual
Labour — floor (3-4 staff)	14%	\$4,024	Manager + 2-3 servers; tip income offsets wages
Rent (prime location)	10%	\$2,874	Budget \$11,496/month; negotiate % of revenue clause
Utilities (high — gas for grills)	6%	\$1,724	Table grills + kitchen; gas cost higher than standard restaurant
Grill maintenance + grates	2%	\$575	Grate replacement, charcoal/gas, ignition systems
Marketing + POS + licences	3%	\$862	SMS platform, social, liquor licence amortised
Miscellaneous + contingency	2%	\$575	Repairs, waste, variance
Total Operating Costs	73%	\$20,981	

Net Operating
Profit

27%

\$7,759/week

~\$403,500/year

10 ALLERGEN SUMMARY TABLE

DISH	GLUTEN	DAIRY	EGGS	FISH	SHELLFISH	SOYA	SESAME	NUTS
Banchan Set	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	✓	—
Haemul Pajeon	✓	—	✓	—	✓	✓	✓	—
Tteokbokki	✓	—	✓	✓	—	✓	—	—
Japchae	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Sundubu Jjigae	✓	—	✓	✓	✓	✓	—	—
Dakgangjeong	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	✓
Chadolbaegi	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Samgyeopsal	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	✓	—
Bulgogi	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Galbi	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Dak Galbi	✓	✓*	—	—	—	✓	✓	—
Doenjang Jjigae	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	—	—
Bibimbap	✓	—	✓	—	—	✓	✓	—
Kimchi Jjigae	✓	—	—	✓	—	✓	—	—
Naengmyeon	✓*	—	✓	—	—	—	—	—
Galbi Jjim	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓	✓
Bingsu	—	✓	—	—	—	—	—	—
Hotteok	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓
Sikhye	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	✓
Yakgwa	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	✓	✓

✓* = depends on specific product/brand. Always verify with suppliers. Cross-contamination risk in shared kitchen environments. Advise guests with severe allergies to inform staff before ordering.

// MICHELIN CHEF'S LENS — KOREA

"I have eaten in Korean BBQ restaurants on four continents. The best ones share a quality that has nothing to do with the quality of the meat or the complexity of the banchan — it is a quality of presence. The servers move with purpose. The banchan bowls are never empty. The grill grates are changed before the smoke turns bitter. The guest feels, though they cannot articulate why, that someone is paying close attention to them throughout the entire meal. This is nunchi — the Korean art of reading the room — and it is the invisible standard that separates a Korean BBQ restaurant that people return to from one they visited once. You can teach the recipes. You can engineer the menu. You can build the P&L model. But the nunchi — the attentive, unhurried, caring presence that makes a guest feel genuinely welcomed — that is the restaurant's soul. Develop it in yourself first. Then teach it to every person you hire."

— Grill together. Build something worth returning to.

